

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL



The original town hall began as the Institute. A meeting on Saturday 1st May 1884 was held at the Junction Hotel and the site offered by the government for the Institute next to the post office in the railway reserve was accepted. An Institute committee was elected and consisted of Messrs Threadgold, Rabbich, Heithersay, Inglis and Brauer.

The Institute was built by Mr Jabez Wright and as being a local, he spared no pains to make everything a success.

The new Institute was formally opened on 31st December 1884. An evening's entertainment of local talent was enjoyed. A fine piano had been purchased by the Institute for 75 guineas. Fundraising events held to raise money for the funding of the Institute including athletics, carnivals, balls, dances, and entertainment.

Many organizations in the town took advantage of having a new building in which to hold their functions. There was a spacious hall, library and reading room.

By 1889 control of the Institute was offered to the council due to bad management and lack of interest.

The council intended to borrow £400 to carry out additions that they thought necessary to use the building as a town hall. They proposed to build two rooms at the front of the hall for the purpose of a new library and reading rooms, so that subscribers could have the use of the library when the hall was being used for other purposes. In 1891 the council had called for tenders to enlarge the stage at the town hall as well as additions to the front of the building.

Both Mr F.W. Dancker and Mr M.F. Cavanagh were corresponded with to submit plans for the front of the Town Hall. The town council approved a design by Mr Dancker, architect of Adelaide, for a two-storey front to the Town Hall. Tenders were invited for the erection of the front which would be an imposing two storey structure.

A public meeting of ratepayers was held on Tuesday 28th June 1992 at the Town Hall. The Council moved *"That this meeting consents to the declaration of a special rate of 4d. in the pound as security for a loan of £1,500 for the purpose of paying off the overdraft and erecting a front to the Town Hall."* The motion was defeated 168 against the proposal and 119 in favour. Mr Dancker was informed that the ratepayers had decided against the town hall additions, and nothing could be done in the matter.

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL

After nearly three years the council announced their intention to borrow £1,000 for the alterations and additions to the old Institute which was now the town hall. A special rate was being levied, and repayment of principal and interest would take 10 years. The town hall was to be lengthened, and a new front erected. The council had decided to change architects, and Mr Cavanagh was asked to submit new plans for the front of the hall. Mr F.W. Dancker whose plans were originals accepted, complained that he had not been treated fairly by the council and took them to court for £26 10s., for work and labour done in connection with the plans of the hall. Mr Dancker's case failed and was awarded £1 6s. for advertising for tenders.

The opening of the additions to the town hall building was held on Thursday 22nd November. The hall was opened by His Excellency the Governor (Earl Kintore) in front of nearly 3,000 people.

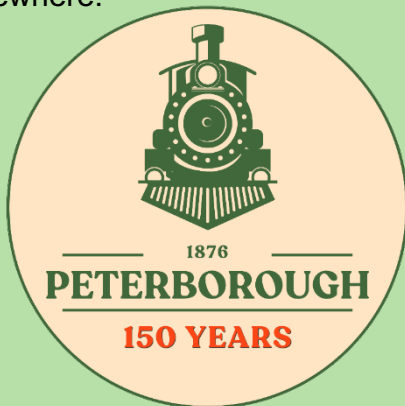


*Parade for opening of additions to Petersburg Town Hall – 22 November 1894
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*

A procession including the Marshal (Mr E.H. Limbert), Mounted Police, Petersburg Brass Band, Rechabites, Forresters, H.A.C.B. Society, Druids, Oddfellows, State School Band, State School and other children and a variety of other societies proceeded to the railway station to greet His Excellency Governor Lord Kintore. The opening of the hall was then held and the school children accompanied by the band sang the "Song of Australia." A private dinner was held at the Railway Hotel followed by a ball in the Town Hall.

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL

Due to the noise of the trains shunting, smoke and soot damage and continual complaints about the size and location of the hall in the railway yards prompted the council to look for another location to build a hall. In 1909 the town council approached the Railway Commissioner with reference to taking over the town hall for railway purposes. As the railway yards were being enlarged the council thought that it would be an opportune time to sell the hall to the railways and build a new hall in some other part of the town. The commissioner had asked for the council to put a price on the building and get back to him. The Railway Commissioner rejected the councils offer for railway purposes as it was too high and due to finances the council were not able to build elsewhere.



Petersburg Town Hall - 1911
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection



For many years discussions on the size of the town hall have been brought up at council and public meetings. The hall itself was too small for most functions and often people were turned away or had to stand outside when there was a concert or event. The 1924 council had given Councillor Goudie the responsibility of investigating the possibility of enlarging the hall as plans to build a new one had been put to the side. Mr Goudie had contacted Mr Smith an architect who had visited Peterborough.

Mr Smith and Mr Goudie had gone through the town hall and looked at the old plan of proposed alterations. The architect then submitted rough drawings for the enlargement of the town hall and an estimated cost without furniture. The Mayor stated that *"According to his reading of the borrowing act, they could not borrow more than £3,500 and the income from the hall would not cover the outlay"*. It was resolved to drop the matter as an unsound financial proposition from the ratepayers point of view.

In 1925 a site near the town hall had been provided by the Railway Commissioner for the building of a Y.M.C.A. A deputation representing the residents of Peterborough was introduced to the Commissioner Mr W.A. Webb, with a request that part of the railway reserve adjacent to the town hall be sold to the corporation to allow the building of a new town hall. As the commissioner was unsure of the requirements of the future railway development in Peterborough he would have to look into the matter, and let them have a reply as early as possible.

The Council received a letter from the Divisional Superintendent S.A.R. stating that the Chief Commissioner was prepared to sell 70 feet of land adjoining the Town Hall site, on east side, for the sum of £10 per foot, the depth of land to be 100 feet. It was moved that the Council accept the offer of the Commissioner, and that as Council was unable to get a depth of 120 feet to request an additional 30 feet in frontage making 100 feet in all as first requested.

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL

At a ratepayers meeting in June 1926 it was decided to hold a ballot to decide whether a new town hall should be erected. The result was 160 in favour of a new hall and 135 against the proposition.

In December Mr Goudie, the chairman of the finance committee of the Peterborough Council announced that the tender of Messrs Silver and Olrich of Alberton, of £10,000 had been accepted for the erection of a new Town Hall. The building of the hall would start in January, and be completed by August 1927. The hall was designed by Mr Chris Hall a well known theatrical architect of Adelaide.



The Corporation of Peterborough has had plans prepared for the erection of a new town hall, municipal offices and shops, and are at present calling for tenders. The illustration shows the front elevation of the proposed two-storey building. Peterborough has long felt the want of an up-to-date hall, and the council is to be commended on the step it is taking as the town is expanding and the terminus of the broad gauge line is to be moved there from Terowie.

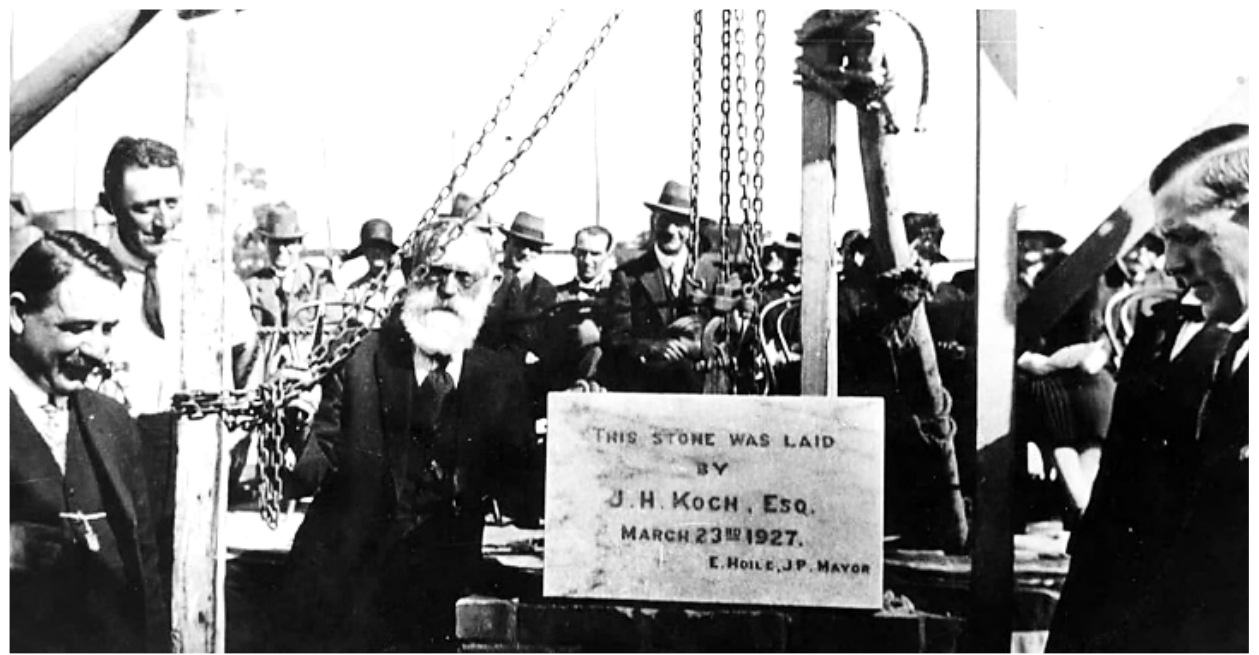
The new hall will be built in the main street on a site between those of the old town hall and the new Young Men's Christian Association building. The new hall and municipal buildings will have a frontage of 120 feet and a depth of 90 feet. The hall will run parallel to the main street and accommodate 350 persons in the dress circle and 950 in the stalls. It will be a fireproof structure of local stone and will have a fine and bold frontage to the main street, with ornamental windows and enriched cornices and mouldings. In addition to the auditorium a large stage will be provided for the use of theatrical

dramas and vaudeville, with commodious supper room beneath. Provision has been made for the projection of moving pictures and a biograph room, to be constructed of fire-resisting materials, will be located at the back of the dress circle. An innovation will be the cooling and ventilating system, which will be of such a high degree of efficiency that the air at all times will be pure and fresh. Provision has been made for two large main entrance vestibules, which will lead to massive staircases giving access to the dress circle, council chambers, library, and offices on the first floor.

The front elevation abutting the main street will have five spacious modern shops with cantilever verandahs. On the ground floor ladies and gentlemen's retiring rooms, elaborately fitted, will be situated in convenient places. The seating accommodation throughout the hall will be heavily sprung and upholstered, and the last word in comfort. Mr. Chris A. Smith, the well-known theatrical architect, of Adelaide, is the architect.

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL

The foundation stone for the new Peterborough Town Hall was laid by Mr Johann Heinrich Koch on Wednesday 23rd March. Mr Koch was one of the earliest pioneers of the district and it was fitting that he should lay the stone, marking another advancement in the town, which previously been dubbed 'Progressive Petersburg.' The Mayor Mr Edward Hoile and the Mayoress, his daughter Mrs R.W. Goudie afterwards entertained Mr and Mrs Koch and family, the council and a few friends at afternoon tea in the old hall. Over 800 children were entertained by the mayor at a picture show in the Capitol Theatre.



Mr J. H. Koch laying the foundation stone of the new Town Hall -1927
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection

As council had failed to sell the old town hall, a further £5000 had to be borrowed to finish the hall and a poll was taken on Saturday 29th October. It was felt that "the Council had not taken the ratepayers into its confidence when dealing with the new hall, and as a consequence had become involved in a tangle." (*The Register*, Saturday 29 October 1927, p. 7). It was voted 109 to 64 in favour of raising the loan. Although it was built in 1927 the hall has 1926 engraved in the stone work at the top of the hall.

The new Peterborough Town Hall was officially opened on Tuesday 15th November 1927 in front of a crowd of about 1,500 people. The Federal Band under the baton of Mr Lou Morgan, rendered an excellent concert in front of the hall before the Town Clerk Mr F.E. Sharman formally handed over the new town hall to the corporation. Mr S.W. Dickson, a former mayor, presented Mr Hoile with a gold key suitably inscribed, and asked him to open the hall. A concert was held after the official opening, with local and visiting performers. Mr W.H. Rodgers loaned his piano for the concert.

The new town hall proved to be an endless task for the council. The shops built at the front had no ventilation and were hot in the summer and the council were charged with the task of trying to get some air circulating. The kitchen was in a bad state and when the copper and stove was used smoke filled the kitchen and hall. The grand piano was only to be used on the stage and many wanted a piano on the floor. Seats in the dress circle were dirty and tacks protruded on the seats. Fans and airducts were installed in the hall and vents were put in the roof to allow foul air to escape.

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - TOWN HALL

The hall had been leased to the Peterborough Entertainment Society in 1928, which limited availability to the ratepayers wanting to hire the hall. The Entertainment Society was formed by ratepayers in May 1928 and a company was set up with 6,000 shares offered at 5/ each. Shares were limited to 20 per person and when 2,500 had been applied for the company started operations. The Society held weekly picture shows and fortnightly dances and 'Talkies' were shown from July 1930.

Due to the noise from the trains in the railway yard and competition from Mr Rees at the Capitol Theatre who received the latest Fox releases by train from Broken Hill (thus being the first to show the new releases in S.A.) the Society found themselves in financial difficulty and being unable to arrive at a working arrangement with the film and machine creditors went into liquidation in July 1931.

A request was then sent to the Council signed by about 30 ratepayers asked that the hall be not leased to any body for any set period of time, many events could not be held there.

In 1932, the council offered the newly formed branch of the Peterborough Country Woman's Association (C.W.A.) temporary accommodation in one of the shops to be used as a rest room until something more suitable came along. The rest room remained at the town hall until December 1967 when the branch moved to new rooms at 89 Main Street which was purchased from Mr Shackleford.

Despite the initial problems the Peterborough Town Hall is one of the most majestic halls in a regional centre in Australia and has been the venue for thousands of balls, cabarets, weddings, funerals, music competitions, calisthenics, meetings and entertainment for the past 100 years.



*New Town Hall – December 1927
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*



*Town Hall and Y.M.C.A. - 2026
Photo – Janet Fielding*